the Kerala Police and the IB, probably to reiterate his apology for having made ‘confessions’ linking me.

I was by now reading the back files and case documents to understand the intricacies of the case. Layer by layer, the conspiracy was unfolding, but the bigger picture, including the international conspiracy, would emerge only later, after the CBI filed its report on 28 April 1996, and the case dragged on till the Supreme Court on 29 April 1998 put an end to the Kerala government’s attempts at reopening it. My battle, however, would not end there.

The local politics behind the case, however, was clear by now. Oommen Chandy, captaining the A K Antony camp of the Congress, was well on his way to topple K Karunakaran from the Chief Minister’s throne. Their trump card was the implication of IG Raman Srivastava in the ISRO spy case. During questioning, Maldivian women Mariam Rasheeda and Fauziyya Hassan had given statements about meeting a man, introduced by Chandrasekhar as ‘Brigadier’. In real, the man they called Brigadier was K L Bhasin, a retired army officer who helped Fauziyya’s daughter get admission to a Bangalore school.

Nicknamed in the case files a ‘Coatwallah’, Bhasin was mistaken for Srivastava, probably because Mariam, while trying to thwart the advances of inspector Vijayan just before her arrest, had said that she would complain about the inspector to the ‘IG’ whom she knew. She had meant the Brigadier, as she told reporters later. The IG in Trivandrum, meanwhile, happened to be Srivastava. Later, examination of some officers found that the IB conveniently did not take on record the fact that the Maldivian women, when showed Bhasin’s photographs, had identified him as the ‘Brigadier’ or ‘Coatwallah’, who Mariam referred to as the IG.

Ironically, aiding this rival Congress team was a Leftist NGO called *Niyamavedi* that demanded the scalp of the IPS officer who was close to Karunakaran. The NGO, represented by an advocate called Nandini moved the Kerala High Court praying for a writ of mandamus directing the CBI to arrest Raman Srivastava on 13 December 1994.